

Checklist:

Careers, Hiring, Performance Management

Career growth

- ☐ Recognize that luck affects careers, and reduce its impact where you can.
- ☐ Focus on creating fair processes for interviewing, promotion, and growth.
- ☐ Map your past year into **eras** and **transitions**.
- ☐ For each transition, identify:
 - ☐ What changed in how you worked.
 - ☐ What skills you relied on.
 - ☐ What skills you developed.
- ☐ Treat both stable periods and transitions as growth opportunities.
- ☐ Do not assume company growth automatically creates personal growth.
- ☐ Look for change, because growth usually comes from navigating change.

Humane interview process checklist

Interview process design

- ☐ Be kind to candidates.
- ☐ Ensure all interviewers agree on the role's requirements.
- ☐ Understand what signal each interview is checking for.
- ☐ Choose interview formats that actually reveal that signal.
- ☐ Come prepared to every interview.
- ☐ Deliberately express interest in candidates.
- ☐ Create feedback loops for interviewers and process designers.
- ☐ Instrument and optimize the hiring funnel.

Candidate experience

- ☐ Allow candidates time to ask questions, especially if the interview runs long.
- ☐ Avoid time-constrained, rushed, or adversarial interview formats.
- ☐ Give overloaded interviewers a break from interviewing.
- ☐ Watch for interviewer burnout.
- ☐ Maintain strong communication between engineering managers and recruiters.
- ☐ Send positive follow-up notes to candidates when appropriate.
- ☐ Ask candidates for feedback on the interview process.

Interview calibration

- ☐ Define the role before interviewing.
- ☐ Agree on required skills and expectations.
- ☐ Break the interview loop into slots that cover all key signals.
- ☐ Use redundancy so more than one interviewer checks important signals.
- ☐ Prefer realistic work samples over artificial puzzles where possible.
- ☐ Have interviewers write feedback independently before group discussion.
- ☐ Pair new interviewers with experienced interviewers.
- ☐ Review candidate feedback and debrief quality regularly.

Cold sourcing checklist

Candidate sources

- ☐ Track candidates by source:
 - ☐ Inbound applicants.
 - ☐ Referrals.
 - ☐ Sourced candidates.
- ☐ Recognize that referrals are limited by personal network size.
- ☐ Watch for network homogeneity when relying heavily on referrals.
- ☐ Use cold sourcing to move beyond existing personal networks.

Cold sourcing process

- ☐ Join or actively use LinkedIn or another professional network.
- ☐ Build your network by connecting with people you actually know.

- ☐ Be patient with platform throttling and slow growth.
- ☐ Search for second-degree connections by title, company, or role.
- ☐ Send short, polite outreach notes.
- ☐ Invite candidates to coffee or a short call.
- ☐ Track who you contacted and what happened.
- ☐ Spend a small, consistent amount of time each week on sourcing.
- ☐ Partner closely with recruiters.
- ☐ Treat sourcing as learning, not just candidate acquisition.

Hiring funnel checklist

Funnel fundamentals

- ☐ Define the hiring funnel:
 - ☐ Identify candidates.
 - ☐ Motivate candidates to apply or engage.
 - ☐ Evaluate candidates.
 - ☐ Close candidates.
- ☐ Clearly define the role.
- ☐ Spend time with candidates to build motivation.
- ☐ Evaluate for certainty, candidate experience, and efficiency.
- ☐ Close by selling the role, expressing need, and spending time.

Instrumentation

- ☐ Track conversion rates at each stage.
- ☐ Track candidate source quality.
- ☐ Track where candidates drop off.
- ☐ Track interviewer load and burnout.
- ☐ Track offer acceptance rates.
- ☐ Track candidate experience feedback.
- ☐ Use the data to decide where to improve first.

Extended funnel

- ☐ Track onboarding success.
- ☐ Track time to productivity.

- ☐ Track employee impact after hiring.
- ☐ Track promotion timing.
- ☐ Track retention.
- ☐ Treat hiring as part of the organization's long-term lifecycle, not just recruiting.

Performance management checklist

System components

- ☐ Define career ladders.
- ☐ Define performance designations.
- ☐ Define performance cycles.
- ☐ Make the system simple enough to understand and use.
- ☐ Use the system to give explicit feedback on how work is valued.

Career ladders

- ☐ Create ladders for roles with enough people to justify them.
- ☐ Keep ladders self-contained and short.
- ☐ Use a shared template across ladders.
- ☐ Define levels clearly.
- ☐ Make level boundaries crisp.
- ☐ Help employees self-assess using the ladder.
- ☐ Avoid creating too many ladders too early.

Performance designations

- ☐ Use designations as explicit statements of performance against expectations.
- ☐ Gather self-review input.
- ☐ Gather peer-review input.
- ☐ Gather upward-review input where relevant.
- ☐ Gather manager-review input.
- ☐ Use calibration to keep ratings consistent and fair.
- ☐ Compare people against the ladder, not against each other.
- ☐ Avoid using performance designations as a substitute for immediate feedback.

Calibration

- ☐ Frame calibration as a quest for consistency.
- ☐ Have participants read reviews rather than rely on presentations.
- ☐ Compare against role expectations.
- ☐ Study rating distributions without forcing a fixed curve.
- ☐ Watch for bias and politicization.
- ☐ Build psychological safety and trust among calibrators.

Performance cycles

- ☐ Decide how often performance cycles happen.
- ☐ Avoid changing the cycle too frequently.
- ☐ Practice the process before running it at scale.
- ☐ Give weak-performance feedback immediately, not only during cycles.
- ☐ Keep performance, promotion, and compensation decisions clear.

Career-level risks checklist

- ☐ Watch for designation momentum.
- ☐ Help employees set clear goals for the designation they aim to achieve.
- ☐ Watch for tit-for-tat favoritism in calibration.
- ☐ Watch for level expansion as the company ages.
- ☐ Watch for level drift and compensation pressure.
- ☐ Manage moments when many people cross level boundaries together.
- ☐ Define career-level limits where useful.
- ☐ Consider level splits carefully.
- ☐ Use crisis- or retention-driven designations only with caution.

Specialized role checklist

Before creating a specialized role

- ☐ Identify the problem the new role is meant to solve.
- ☐ Check whether the issue can be solved by adjusting an existing ladder.
- ☐ Check whether the function already exists informally.

- ☐ Ask whether the role will improve recognition without limiting long-term career growth.
- ☐ Confirm enough people will be affected to justify the role.
- ☐ Decide who will maintain the role over time.

Risks to consider

- ☐ Class-system dynamics.
- ☐ Brittle organization design.
- ☐ Pattern matching from other companies.
- ☐ Task offloading.
- ☐ Work being viewed as trivial.
- ☐ Work being valued for impact but not promotion.
- ☐ Headcount planning obstacles.
- ☐ Unrealistically high hiring bars.
- ☐ Difficulty evaluating candidates.

Success requirements

- ☐ Secure an executive or senior sponsor.
- ☐ Ensure recruiting support.
- ☐ Define a self-sustaining mission.
- ☐ Create a career ladder from the beginning.
- ☐ Identify external and internal role models.
- ☐ Run dedicated calibration for the specialized role.

Benefits to validate

- ☐ Increased efficiency.
- ☐ Better ability to solve constraints.
- ☐ Improved recognition of specialized work.
- ☐ Better evaluation of specialist strengths.
- ☐ Increased hiring pool.
- ☐ Appropriate specialized compensation where needed.

Interview loop design checklist

- ☐ Start with metrics from the hiring funnel.
- ☐ Understand current loop performance.
- ☐ Review funnel performance.
- ☐ Review employee trajectory after hiring.
- ☐ Conduct candidate debriefs.
- ☐ Learn from peer companies.
- ☐ Identify role models for the role.
- ☐ Identify the skills that matter most.
- ☐ Design a test for each skill.
- ☐ Avoid testing for polish by accident.
- ☐ Create a rubric for every test.
- ☐ Avoid Boolean rubrics when they do not provide sufficient signal.
- ☐ Group tests into coherent interviews.
- ☐ Run the loop.
- ☐ Review the hiring funnel after 10–20 candidates.
- ☐ Schedule an annual refresh.
- ☐ Avoid design by committee.
- ☐ Do not hire for vague “potential” unless you have an objective rubric.
- ☐ Reuse the career ladder where possible.
- ☐ Iterate interviews a little.
- ☐ Iterate rubrics a lot.
- ☐ Consider A/B testing loops at sufficient scale.
- ☐ Use hiring committees to detect patterns and maintain fairness.
- ☐ Avoid reusing interview material that you already know does not work.